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Nyae Nyae region of Namibia and Botswana

Section Title(S): TALKING AND 'TALKS'

As far as we know, only two general subjects are taboo in conversation. Men and women must not speak openly together of sexual matters except as they make jokes in the joking relationship. The !Kung avoid speaking the names of the gods aloud and do not converse about the gods for fear of attracting their attention and perhaps their displeasure. They told us their myths, but only when we asked them to. It is evidently not the habit of these Bushmen to recount the myths as they sit by their fires. They do not invent stories. They said they had no interest in hearing things that are not true and wonder why anybody has.

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While a person speaks the listeners are in vibrant response, repeating the phrases and interposing a contrapuntal 'eh'. 'Yesterday', 'eh', 'at Deboragu', 'eh', 'I saw old /Gaishay.' 'You saw Old /Gaishay', 'eh, eh'. 'He said he had seen the great python under the bank.' 'EH!', 'The PYTHON!' 'He wants us', 'eh, eh, eh', 'to help him catch it'. The 'ehs' overlap and coincide with the phrase and the people so often all talk at once that one wonders how anyone knows what the speaker has said.

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Bursts of laughter accompany the conversations. Sometimes the !Kung laugh mildly with what I would call a sense of humour about people and events, often they shriek and howl as though laughter were an outlet for tension. They laugh at mishaps that happen to other people, like the lions eating up someone else's meat, and shriek over particularly telling and insulting sexual sallies in the joking relationship. Individual singing of lyrical songs, accompanied by the //guashi, or snatches of the medicine music, the playing

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of rhythmical games, the ceremonial dances themselves occupy the evenings, as well, but mostly the evening hours are spent in talk.

'A talk', as the !Kung call it, differs from a conversation or an arranged, purposeful discussion. It flares spontaneously, I believe from stress, when something is going on in which people are seriously concerned and in disagreement. I think that no formalities control it. Anyone who has something he wants to say joins in. People take sides and express opinions, accusing, denying, or defending persons involved. I witnessed one 'talk' only, in 1952, which I mentioned before¹ and should mention again in this context. It occurred over a gift-giving episode at the time of !Nai's betrothal and involved persons in Bands 1 and 2 who were settled near together at the time. Khuan//a, the mother of /Gunda, !Nai's fiancé, had diverted a gift which people thought was making its way to Gao Medicine, the present husband of !Nai's mother. Instead of giving it to him at the time when an exchange of gifts was in order, she gave it to one of her relatives. !Nai's mother's sister, !U, sitting at her own scherm, began 'the talk' by letting it be known what she thought of Khuan//a, in a voice loud enough to be heard in the two werfs, a startling contrast to the usual low flow of talk. Di/ai, !Nai's mother, sitting with her shoulder pressed against her sister's, joined in. People in the werfs went to sit at each other's scharms, forming little groups ■ 234 who agreed and supported each other. From where they sat, but not all at once and not in an excited babble, they made their remarks clearly, with quite long pauses between. Some expressed themselves in agreement with !U as she recounted Khuan//a's faults and deviations, past and present. Khuan//a's family and friends, who had moved to sit near her, denied the accusations from time to time, but did not talk as much or as loudly as !U. Khuan//a muttered or was silent. !U said she disapproved of her sister's daughter marrying the son of such a woman, but would reconsider her position if Khuan//a gave the expected gift to Gao Medicine. The talk lasted about twenty minutes. At that point Khuan//a got up and walked away and the 'talk' subsided to !U's mutterings and others' low conversation. In a few days Khuan//a gave Gao Medicine a present, not the gift in question, but one which satisfied Gao, and, as they said, 'they all started again in peace'.

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¹ Lorna Marshall, 'Marriage Among !Kung Bushmen', *Africa*, vol. xxix, no. 4, Oct. 1959, pp. 352-3.

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